The *Elevation*

Notes on buildings, cities, and the people who draw them · Studio Merrow Architects

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The Grain Exchange Gets a Second Century

After eleven years of false starts, the 1907 landmark reopens in September as a public market, archive, and 220 apartments — with its trading floor intact.

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When our survey team first walked the Calloway Grain Exchange in 2015, the trading floor was ankle-deep in pigeon guano and the famous laylight — four hundred panes of amber glass — had lost nearly a third of its panels to a decade of hail seasons. What the building had not lost was its structure: a riveted steel frame, generously overbuilt in the fashion of its era, that our engineers rated capable of carrying five stories more than it ever had.

That surplus capacity became the project's financial engine. By transferring the unused load allowance into a slender residential bar along the rail-yard elevation, the development consortium could fund a full restoration of the trading hall without a single public-facing square foot of it becoming leasable office space. The hall instead returns to the city as a covered market, its original oak trading posts refitted as vendor stalls.

The archive occupies the old weighing vaults below grade. Climate control there posed the project's hardest detailing problem: the vault walls could not be furred out without destroying the stenciled tally marks left by three generations of grain inspectors, so conditioning runs through the floor — a plenum assembly our team developed with Harwick Mechanical and has since documented for open use by other preservation practices.

Residents begin moving in the first week of September; the market opens for the fall harvest. The laylight's missing panes were recast this winter by the Oleander Glassworks from sand sourced at the original quarry. On a clear afternoon the floor turns the color of wheat — which is, of course, the point.

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> *“Preservation isn't keeping a building the way it was. It's keeping it in the habit of mattering.”*
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> OLIVE MERROW, FOUNDING PRINCIPAL — 1962

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